



ALEX WROBLEWSKI AFP/Getty Images

LANDMARK IMMIGRATION CASE

Immigrant rights supporters rally outside the U.S. Supreme Court on Wednesday as the justices heard arguments in the government’s effort to end Temporary Protected Status for noncitizens. **NATION, A7**

Push for more vacation rentals in L.A.

For Olympics, Bass wants to ease rules on second homes. Critics fear effect on housing.

By Noah Goldberg

Owners of second homes — and Airbnb — stand to reap a windfall under an initiative in Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass’ new city budget proposal.

Tucked away in the more than 500 pages of city budget expenditures, the mayor calls for creating a new revenue stream by allowing people who own a second home to rent it out on a short-term basis, something that is currently prohibited.

The mayor’s office says the measure would provide additional tax revenue for the city and extra beds for visitors during the 2028 Summer Olympics, with the measure expiring at the end of that year. To take effect, the City Council would need to approve a vacation rental ordinance.

Expanding the short-term rental market out of the city’s existing housing stock is fiercely opposed by the hotel workers union and hotel companies, as well as by affordable housing advocates who say it will further deplete the city’s limited housing stock.

City Council members voiced some of those same concerns at a meeting of the Budget and Finance Committee on Tuesday.

“I have a list of dozens and dozens of [rent-stabilized] units in my district ... that are currently Airbnb units. This is happening,” Councilmember Eunisses Hernandez said.

[See Rentals, A5]

D.C. breach highlights Secret Service failures

Security measures, response to gunman faulted

By Kevin Rector and Richard Winton

According to acting Atty. Gen. Todd Blanche and other top administration officials, the U.S. Secret Service did a fine job protecting President Trump and Cabinet members from the gunman who breached the White House Correspondents’ Assn. dinner Saturday.

“That horrible act was stopped because of the courage and professionalism of law enforcement — the officers who responded without hesitation and did their jobs as they were trained to do,” Blanche said Monday.

However, according to a detailed accounting filed Wednesday by federal prosecutors in the criminal case against suspect Cole Tomas Allen, the performance of the nation’s preeminent protection agency was marred by inattentiveness and misfires and saved by “extraordinary good fortune” and the gunman

falling to the ground.

“The defendant, armed with a 12-gauge shotgun, a .38 caliber pistol, two knives, four daggers, and enough ammunition to take dozens of lives, was apprehended by [Secret Service] officers mere feet away from the ballroom where his primary target was located, along with other members of the Cabinet,” prosecutors wrote Wednesday, in a filing arguing for Allen to be held in detention pending trial on one charge of trying to kill the president and two firearms charges.

Contradicting a prior claim by Blanche that officers had “promptly tackled and detained” Allen, prosecutors wrote that the 31-year-old tutor from Torrance simply “fell to the ground” after blowing past a team of agents just two open flights of stairs from the ballroom.

They wrote [See Breach, A7]

GALA MYSTERY: There is a lot we don’t know about suspect Cole Tomas Allen and the attack at the White House correspondents’ dinner. **NATION, A7**

Big Oil backing World Cup

Global giant Saudi Aramco is among the event’s top sponsors despite FIFA sustainability pledge

By Hayley Smith



AARON SCHWARTZ Bloomberg

GIANNI INFANTINO is president of FIFA. The group’s goals include net-zero emissions by 2040.

As FIFA prepares to bring the largest-ever World Cup to Los Angeles and other parts of North America this summer, the global soccer organization is again promoting a commitment to environmental sustainability. But some of its sponsorship agreements tell a different story — including a premiere deal with the largest oil and gas company in the world, Saudi Aramco.

FIFA and Aramco first announced their four-year global partnership agreement in late 2024, which means the fossil fuel giant’s logo is likely to be visible on the field, online and on TV during this year’s World Cup and the Women’s World Cup in 2027. Aramco, which is almost entirely owned by the government of Saudi Arabia, has secured the highest level of sponsorship along with Adidas, Coca-Cola, Hyundai and Kia, Lenovo.

[See Sponsor, A5]

Voting Rights Act is curbed by Supreme Court

Impact on minority representation in Congress could be huge, legal experts say.

By David G. Savage and Ana Ceballos

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court’s conservative majority on Wednesday sharply limited a part of the Voting Rights Act that has forced states to draw voting districts to help elect Black or Latino representatives to Congress as well as state and local boards.

In a 6-3 decision in *Louisiana vs. Callais*, the court ruled that creating these majority-minority districts may amount to racial discrimination that violates the 14th Amendment.

When weighing what the Voting Rights Act requires, “we start with the general rule that the Constitution almost never permits the federal government or a state to discriminate on the basis of race,” Justice Samuel A. Alito Jr. wrote for the court.

Alito said states may

draw election districts for partisan advantage but may not use race as a basis for redistricting.

The ruling in a Louisiana case appears to clear the way for Republican-led states across the South to redraw their election maps and eliminate voting districts that favor Black or Latino candidates for Congress, state legislatures and county boards.

UCLA law professor Rick Hasen said, “It is hard to overstate what an earthquake this will be for American politics,” adding that the decision makes the Voting Rights Act a “much weaker, and potentially toothless law.”

Hasen said it’s unclear how the decision will affect the November election because in many states early voting has already started and primaries have already taken place.

But the ruling’s long-term consequences for minority representation in Congress, state legislatures and local government are almost “certainly” going to be felt in 2028, Hasen said.

[See Voting, A6]



BRIAN VAN DER BRUG Los Angeles Times

THE LAPD has an aging fleet of 17 helicopters. Drones will complement them, officials say.

LAPD expands use of drones sharply

They are cheaper to run than choppers, but critics worry about surveillance.

By Libor Jany

The LAPD’s black-and-white helicopters have long been a fixture of local skies, allowing the police to track suspects and patrol the city from above.

Now, the air traffic is growing more crowded with the expansion of the department’s drone fleet.

The Los Angeles Police Department has increasingly come to rely on small, unmanned aerial vehicles since launching a “drone as a first responder” pilot program in July.

In a report presented Tuesday to the Police Commission, LAPD officials said drones were deployed more than 3,000 times last year, mostly in response to emergency calls or officer requests for assistance.

In recent months, the devices have been deployed to

incidents including home break-ins and calls about armed suspects. An online dashboard of LAPD flight activity showed they were used at least 39 times in one day this month.

The LAPD drones are propelled by four sets of rotors. Each drone is about 3 feet wide and equipped with cameras and infrared night vision. Department officials say the drones take off from launchpads that are strategically placed around the city.

Once airborne, they can cover two miles in roughly two minutes, allowing police to more quickly get eyes on crime scenes and determine the level of appropriate response.

The first LAPD helicopters took flight in 1956 to help monitor traffic along the city’s growing highway system. Drones have been part of the department’s arsenal for just over a decade, but until recently their use was restricted to a narrow set of incidents, most involving barricaded suspects or bomb threats.

[See Drones, A5]

Hegseth faces lawmakers’ Iran questions

Democrats assail the Defense secretary on the war’s cost and mission at a House panel hearing. **NATION, A4**

Clash of governor candidates

They spar in a fiery debate that may finally grab voters’ attention just weeks before the primary. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

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Markets **A11**
Opinion Voices **A12**

James Conlon’s farewell begins

L.A. Opera’s music director is ending his tenure with comedies. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Lakers try to close out Rockets

For coverage of Game 5 against Houston, visit latimes.com/enewspaper and latimes.com/sports.

Weather

Mostly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 73/57. **B6**



Drones, pot and a string of SoCal heists

Police say mastermind recruited thieves via Instagram. A break-in ended in murder.

By Matthew Ormseth

Johnny Johnson was at a friend’s birthday party in Hollywood when he got a message on Instagram.

Johnson didn’t recognize the account that sent the message early that Friday morning in 2023, but it conveyed an offer he found hard to resist: Was he interested

in burglarizing a cannabis grow in exchange for 10 pounds of the take?

“I’m a nice person,” Johnson testified nearly two years later at his trial on murder charges. “I always say yes and that’s been my downfall for my entire life.”

So Johnson drove toward Chatsworth, guided by Instagram messages from a person he didn’t know.

“It sounds crazy,” he told the jury, “but it’s the truth.”

The job went terribly wrong. There was an unexpected confrontation, a shootout and a car left drifting down a silent street with

a dead man behind the wheel.

The investigation led police to a man now accused of orchestrating a staggering array of thefts: Hoverboards from a warehouse in Vernon. Watches from the Waldorf Astoria hotel in Beverly Hills. Millions’ worth of Hermes bags snatched in late-night break-ins in West L.A. and Newport Beach.

But his primary targets, authorities say, were marijuana grows. According to testimony and other evidence presented in court, the organizer of the thefts used drones to pick his tar-

gets.

Then he sent in crews of young men who typically didn’t know one another. Like the robbers of Quentin Tarantino’s “Reservoir Dogs” who referred to each other only by colors — Mr. White, Mr. Pink — Johnson told the detectives the crew had operated with strict anonymity, never revealing their real names to each other.

“Whoever put this s— together, they done put a team together. You feel me?” Johnson said, according to a tape of the interview.

[See Burglaries, A6]